numbers of helpless sepoys stranded in Afghanistan. ‘The name and character of the British must suffer in the opinion of our own subjects and soldiers in India if we were to pay for the release of a few Europeans,’ he wrote,

> while so many thousands of our native soldiery & camp followers are reduced to the condition of slavery throughout this country. Many other poor wretches who are deprived of their hands and feet or otherwise mutilated or diseased are supporting their precarious existence by begging. If these latter persons be not released many if not all must die in the coming winter, and it appears to me that the Government will lay itself open to the odium and charge of undue partiality if it release us alone by ransom.[60]

There was, moreover, some urgency to the situation of the stranded Indians. A slave trader who visited the fortress where the hostages were being kept told Lady Sale that ‘400 Hindoostanees have been entrapped at Kabul, under an assurance of safe conduct to Jalalabad . . . Men sell for forty-six rupees; and women for twenty-two, each.’ Uzbek slave traders who dominated the Afghan market were especially feared for the merciless brutality they habitually displayed to their captives. When Josiah Harlan had passed through Khulm he described the ‘diabolical contrivance’ by which the Uzbeks literally sewed their captives to their saddles. ‘To oblige the prisoner to keep up, a strand of course horsehair is passed by means of a long crooked needle, under and around the collar bone, a few inches from its junction at the sternum; with the hair a loop is formed to which they attach a rope that may be fastened to the saddle. The captive is constrained to keep near the retreating horseman, and with his hands tied behind his person, is altogether helpless.’[61] When Akbar warned Pollock that, if he attempted to retake Kabul, all the British prisoners of war would immediately be sent north to be sold as slaves in the Bukhara slave markets, the hostages had good reason to be apprehensive.

The British prisoners were staying in relative comfort in a fort just outside Kabul when Akbar Khan heard that the armies of Pollock and Nott had begun advancing on his capital from two different directions. His closest ally, Mohammad Shah Khan Ghilzai, encouraged him to prepare for a final life-or-death struggle with the Kafirs. ‘War they want,’ he told his son-in-law. ‘Let them have it – war to the knife. Let us destroy them all.’[62] That Friday the Wazir rode to the Pul-i-Khishti Masjid and from the pulpit made a passionate appeal for a last and conclusive jihad against the British.